

ASHOK PATNI

54, MARBLE TRADER
CHAIRMAN, R K MARBLE GROUP
INVESTMENT IN 1988 Rs 1 lakh
TURNOVER IN 2008 Rs 200 crore

SUCCESS MANTRA

Care for customers
and employees.
Business will happen.

midas TOUCH

Kishangarh has
become Asia's biggest
marble market

on his GROWTH

Everyday 6 lakh sq ft
of RK Marble is used
all over the country



PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

THE WHITE TIGER

When Ashok Patni drives a golf cart around his neatly laid, corporate-style RK Marble complex in Kishangarh, Rajasthan, he can't help remembering his humble beginnings. The small cabin from where he sold marble in 1988, now graced by an electricity meter, is on Patni's way every morning as he steps out of his Mercedes Benz for another day of work.

Back then his 19-year-old brother Vimal insisted on diversifying from the family's wholesale grain business. He bought raw marble from Rajsamand, and cut and sold it at Kishangarh. There was little competition. Six months later, an injury to Vimal led Patni into the domain. The account books showed a profit of Rs 1 lakh on the seed capital that Ashok had given Vimal. "We can do better if I get into this business as well," Patni decided at that moment. The same day he bought 1 lakh sq yards of land nearby.

The new factory began in June 1989 and in the first two months he earned Rs 3 lakh—what the entire family would earlier make in one year by selling grain. Patni, a commerce graduate, who left two

dud ventures—selling matchboxes and making soap cakes—behind him, saw great potential in marble. It had many advantages over the grain business. It was not covered under the Essential Commodities Act and there was no fear of inspectors accusing him of hoarding. What's more, no one would steal the heavy rocks that had an endless shelf life. However, there were problems too, as the trade came under the unorganised sector. Miners rarely delivered material on time and it would often be of a quality inferior to what had been promised. Patni then decided to lease his own mines, 15 in six districts of Rajasthan around 1990. A sprawling mine in Morwad in Rajsamand district in 1993

brought in a sea change. From 100 tonnes a month in 1993, the production today has risen to 12,000 tonnes a day. Patni now employs 5,000 people, who get production-linked incentives. "When they stop production on my visits to the mines, the labourers feel upset as it means lower production and lower incentives for them," he says.

Being an outsider and having fresh ideas helped Patni flourish in the business. Some legends are carved in stone. Patni is one of them. **by Rohit Parihar**

**PATNI TRIED SELLING
MATCHBOXES AND
MAKING SOAP CAKES
BEFORE REALISING
THE POTENTIAL OF
MARBLE TRADING
AND IN JUST TWO
MONTHS HE MADE
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AS HE WOULD HAVE
IN A YEAR IN THE
GRAIN BUSINESS.**